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The second edition of the Chennai Open, a WTA 250 event, is set to take place at the SDAT Stadium in Nungambakkam from October 27 to November 2.

The tournament was previously held on a single-year licence in 2022, when the then 17-year-old Linda Fruhvirtova of Czechia won her maiden title. The upcoming edition coincides with the centenary year of the Tamil Nadu Tennis Association (TNTA).

The event arrives at a time when women's tennis in India has shown encouraging signs. Maaya Rajeshwaran Revathi has emerged as a new hope in singles and a bright prospect for the future — particularly after her stunning run to the semifinals of the WTA 125 Mumbai Open in February as a qualifier.

The 16-year-old from Coimbatore, who trains at the prestigious Rafa Nadal Academy, also made her junior Grand Slam main-draw debut at last month's U.S. Open.

As a team too, India's players impressed by finishing second among six teams in the Billie Jean King Cup Asia-Oceania Group I tournament in Pune, thereby qualifying for the World Group play-offs for only the second time under the current structure. Shrivalli Bhamidipaty came into the limelight with her flawless 5-0 singles record — a major factor behind India's success.

The momentum continued when World No. 337 Sahaja Yamalapalli, the country's top-ranked player, defeated 2017 U.S. Open champion Sloane Stephens in straight sets at a WTA 125 event in Mexico last week.

While Maaya and Sahaja were granted main-draw wildcards for the Chennai Open in the first list announced on October 17, Shrivalli

became the third Indian to secure one three days later, after World No. 37 Lois Boisson — this year's surprise French Open semifinalist — withdrew due to injury. Junior Wimbledon champion Mia Pohankova, the 16-year-old Slovak, has received the fourth and final wildcard.

Karman Kaur Thandi, whose career has been derailed by multiple injuries since her upset of France's Chloé Paquet in the 2022 edition, has used a Special Ranking to enter the qualifying rounds. Two wildcards for the qualifiers, scheduled for October 25–26, are also likely to be handed to local players. Riya Bhatia, Prarthana Thombare, Rutuja Bhosale and Ankita Raina are among the Indians in the doubles draw.

Realistically, it would be ambitious to expect an Indian player to replicate Sania Mirza's Hyderabad Open triumph in 2005 — still the country's only singles title on the main tour — but a deep run to the semifinals could provide a significant boost towards qualifying for next season's Australian Open.

From an international perspective, Paris Olympics silver medallist Donna Vekic, and former Wimbledon semifinalists Tatjana Maria and Lulu Sun will be the main stars to watch. But there will be no Top 10 player in action, as two other WTA 250 events in Hong Kong and Jiangxi, China, take place during the same week, ahead of the season-ending WTA Finals in Riyadh from November 1.

Chennai has a rich history of hosting tour-level events but majorly

for men. An ATP 250 tournament was held annually from 1997 to 2017. The city continues to host a Challenger Tour event — the second tier of men's tennis — each year. However, as far as women's events are concerned, there have been only six international tournaments in the city since 2001: five ITFs (the lowest tier of professional tennis) and the inaugural WTA Chennai Open three years ago. For this year's edition, TNTA President and Indian tennis legend Vijay Amritraj coordinated with Octagon — the sports agency holding the three-year licence for the event — to relocate the tournament from Mexico. Whether the city retains the WTA 250 event for 2026–27 will depend on how this edition unfolds.

The organisers have done their due diligence by upgrading the venue. Three courts have been re-laid, offering medium to slow-medium surfaces. To handle the rain and wet conditions as the event coincides with the onset of the monsoon, each court will be tended to by a separate crew. "Even if it rains an hour before play, the courts will be bone dry," said Amritraj at a press conference last week.

Matches on all three courts will be televised (Eurosport and Doordarshan), and the challenge system will be available on all of them. However, Hawk-Eye technology will be restricted to the centre court.

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